

LESSON 3: Physical Forms of a Catalogue

2.2 Physical Forms of a Catalogue

The Physical Forms of a Catalogue include the following;

- Book Form Catalogue
- Sheaf Form
- Card Form
- Accessories Registers
- MARC (Machine Readable Catalogue) etc.

2.2.1 Advantages and disadvantages of each of the above Forms

Book Form Catalogue

This is a catalogue in which catalogue entries are hand-written or printed and bound into a volume or a book. Many big libraries like British Museum, Calcutta National Library have such catalogues. It is also known as Printed Book catalogue. This kind of catalogue has been a traditional form adopted in many large libraries. Some big libraries used to publish a general printed catalogue of their collection up to date and then issue periodical supplements to keep the original volume up to date.

The book catalogue is a catalogue of books bound in a volume where entries are printed or written on pages. This form of catalogue was developed from the very early days of printing itself. It is also known as Printed Page Catalogue.

Advantages Book Form Catalogue

- **Familiar.** Since this type is a traditional type, people are familiar with this and hence it creates less psychological barrier to the readers.
- **Easy to handle.** Since this type is almost like a conventional type of a book, it is very easy to handle. The catalogue can be referred to with greater speed since opening pages is simple.
- **Economy.** Due to economic problems small libraries are preparing this type for use.

- **Portability.** Number of copies can be printed and distributed. It is portable. Every Reader can have a copy for his or her reference outside the library
- **Span of vision.** Since this type has many entries on a page, one can go through many entries at a time. The user can see several entries at the same time.
- **Reparable.** Missing pages if there is any missing of pages, it can easily be detected and Rectified because every page is numbered serially. This is not possible in card catalogue because the cards are not numbered.
- **Book selection tool.** This catalogue is used as a book selection tool. It can be used as a reference and book selection tool by other libraries.
- **Saves space.** The catalogue occupies less space.
- **Sharable.** Several readers can refer to the catalogue at the same time by sharing viewing.
- **Publicity tool.** Publicity Since this type of catalogue is portable; it gives more publicity to the library.

Disadvantages Book Form Catalogue

- **Expensive.** The catalogue is too laborious and expensive to produce and compile. Too much of editorial work is involved and as a result, many staff members have to be appointed. This is true if the library is big.
- **Up-to-datedness.** The greatest drawback is up-to-datedness. Latest additions will not find a place in the book catalogue. There is no facility for inserting new entries.
- **Tedious.** Time to find a particular entry one has to go through many entries and sometimes a number of books, thereby consuming a lot of time.
- **Durability.** It is less durable since the book can get torn or lost.
- **Cooperative cataloguing.** This is not possible as cataloguing services are available on books.
- **Guiding.** There is no facility of guiding the users in this form of catalogue.
- **Loss.** The catalogue can be easily lost since a book can be carried out of library by the users or any malicious person
- **Sharability.** The catalogue can only be satisfactorily used by one person at a time.
- **Weeding out.** For missing books, the entries are to be weeded out. This is not possible in book catalogue.

i. **Sheaf Form catalogue**

This is a form of a catalogue made by sheets, slips or cards fastened in a binder that permits the inserting new material. Its first use was made by the Leyden library Holland.

Advantages of a Sheaf Form Catalogue

- The catalogue has a facility of insertion and removal of entries.
- With this form more than one entry can be prepared on a slip.
- Preparing entries is easier and cheaper to produce.
- The catalogue occupies less space in the library.
- The catalogue is easier to handle and can be removed from the stand.
- This form of catalogue is suitable for large libraries.
- The catalogue is reliable since it is always in the library.

Disadvantages of a Sheaf Form Catalogue

- It is wastage of stationery since one book is entered on one slip.
- If three books are entered the catalogue becomes overcrowded and needs retyping.
- Carbon copies of the catalogue are not so pleasant as that of original.
- The catalogue uses slips of paper which are less durable.
- The process of insertion and withdrawal is not so easy.
- Cooperative cataloguing is not possible in this form of catalogue.
- Guiding provide by this form is not satisfactory to the users.
- Catalogue can only be consulted/ used within the library.



ii. **Card Form catalogue**

This is a form of catalogue where the entries are made and arranged on cards of uniform size of 12.5 cm x 7.5 cm and kept in drawers of catalogue cabinet.



The **card catalogue** was a familiar sight to library users for generations, but it has been effectively replaced by the (OPAC). Some still refer to the online catalogue as a card catalogue. Some libraries with OPAC access still have card catalogs on site, but these are now strictly a secondary resource and are seldom updated. Many libraries that retain their physical

card catalog will post a sign advising the last year that the card catalog was updated. Some libraries have eliminated their card catalog in favor of the OPAC for the purpose of saving space for other use, such as additional shelving.

Advantages Card Form Catalogue

- The catalogue allows inserting and withdrawal of cards this keeps it up to date.
- The users can be easily guided on the use of the cards.
- Entries prepared on cards is easier to consult and handle by the users.
- Card catalogue is more durable from other physical forms.
- The cards can be arranged in any desired order by the cataloguer.
- Cooperative cataloguing is possible in this form of a catalogue.
- This form is more economic to maintain and cards can be changed at any time.
- The cards also can present a neat appearance since they are of the same size.

Disadvantages Card Form Catalogue

- This form of catalogue occupies much space of the library.
- With this form of only one user can consult catalogue at a time.
- This catalogue is not portable.
- It can only be consulted within the library where it is.
- With this form marking cards and cabinets are too expensive
- The readers can also easily take out the cards and take them.
- Most users do not know how to consult it.

Iv. Accessories Registers

This is form of catalogue where the entries of documents are written in hand in a bound registers or ledger. For example, accessions register user borrowing registers of the library.

Advantages Accessories Registers

- The readers can use this catalogue with unquestionable ease.
- The reader can consult the circulation counter or reference desk.
- More than two readers can use it because it is portability.
- The reader can also see several entries on same page which saves precious time.
- It does not copy much space of the library
- It doesn't require special equipment to display due to its compactness.
- It much more convenient to consult it because it like a book or register.

Disadvantages Accessories Registers

- This form does not allow inserting of new books entries.
- This form cannot be kept up to date since at times or period the register is closed.
- The quality of paper used is not thick as the card catalogue making it less durable.

- It can easily be of stolen, damaged, turnout, mutilated by the users.
- Most users do not ask for it because of its name most of them prefer other catalogues.
- It is expensive to make and requires trained personnel to manage it and update.
- The arrangement is not uniform since there are no rules to follow when making the registers.

<i>LIBRARY ACCESSION REGISTER</i>									
Accession no.	Date arrived	Author	Place of publication	publisher	Year of publish	price	Source	Class no.	Notes

v. **MARC (Machine Readable Catalogue)**

These Catalogues are prepared on a magnetic tape or magnetic disc and accessed by use of network or internet. Examples include:

- Visible Index

This catalogue consists of strips mounted on a frame or cards held flat, hinged and with edge of each card protecting so as to make the heading visible.

- Microform Catalogue

This is a form of catalogue where the entries are reduced and printed upon a film or fiche.

This not common because microfilm machines are expensive.

- Online Public Access Catalogue (OPAC)

This is online public access catalogue which can be compatible with the web 2.0 technologies or accessed on the internet.

Advantages of MARC (Machine Readable Catalogue)

- These forms of catalogues are usually kept update.
- The catalogues can be used by users with a high level of efficiency.
- They can be searched with high speed due to use of internet and computers.
- The catalogues are compact that is they can have very many entries.
- They occupy less space since they are stored on networks and computers.

- They are portability and can be accessed anywhere as long as there is connection.
- Multiple copies can be generated at the lower cost and cheap to make.
- Corporative cataloguing is possible with this catalogue form.

Disadvantages of MARC (Machine Readable Catalogue)

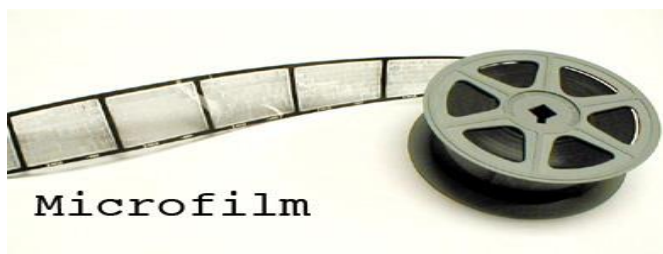
- They are very expensive to make and develop.
- They require users to have computer skill to use the catalogue.
- The catalogue can be affected by power shortages.
- Maintain this form if catalogue requires experts in computer making it not easy.
- This form of catalogue can kill library spirit of the users since they can access outside.
- All data can be lost in case of virus attack or hackers on the catalogue.
- Users may not use this kind of catalogue if they are not familiar with computers.
- They also follow new code of cataloguing that is RDA yet most people prefer AACR2.

Vi. Microform Catalogues

Microform is a general term for any material that contains a small image or micro reproduction of a document. These document images are usually found on film. There are two common film formats: **microfilm and microfiche**;

- **Microfilm** is a roll of film.
- **Microfiche** is a flat sheet of film.

The images are so small and therefore **special readers/scanners are used to view the documents**. Microforms help to save space. Thousands of newspapers, journals or government documents can be stored in a few cabinets.





Advantages of Microform Catalogues

- Saves library space , up to 95% because the catalogues are part of the collection
- Cost savings in terms of reproduction & distribution.
- The print medium is archival stable and has an estimated shelf life of over 500 years.
- Information can be recovered from the medium with a magnifying glass.

Disadvantages of Microform Catalogues

- Patrons must use magnification to use the medium
- Reader/scanners can be difficult to operate
- Reader/scanners can break down or not be available
- Items can be easily misfiled in high density cases
- Not as convenient and lacks features available in digital formats
- Expensive Readers and scanners are needed to retrieve information

vii. Guard Book Catalogue

It is a variation of book catalogue. In this form entries are printed or typed on a slip and kept in arranged manner in guard book after pasting each slip on a thicker sheet. More than one entry is normally pasted on one sheet and sufficient vacant spaces are left to accommodate new entries. If vacant spaces are less than the entries to be pasted, one or two sheets are taken out and cancelled and new sheets are added after pasting new entries as well as old entries appearing on cancelled sheet in appropriate order.

Advantages and Disadvantages of Guard Book Catalogue

The Guard Book Catalogue's merits and demerits are more or less similar to book catalogue. But it decidedly has better qualities of being updated and is more flexible than book catalogue. The work and process of updating it is time consuming and complicated. It occupies more sheets in appropriate order.

Guard Book Catalogue

